Climate Tourism



The heat had ratcheted up to the point that just about everyone on earth was frantic to do whatever they could to stop it. The well off still went on their vacations, but now they took them at the edge of the Amazon rain forest, where they volunteered to help plow up farms and replant trees. When there were too many tourists there, some went to Greenland.

Minik worked at the Nuuk Tourist Center. His job was to take care of the rich tourists who came trying to make things better, to help with the Big Freeze. He gave them the standard motivational talk and let them settle in after the evening buffet, but now, this morning, there was work to be done. He got them all in their puffy white freezer suits with the condenser backpacks, gave each one a pail, and then put them into water taxis to get near the edge of Sermitsiaq Glacier. There he directed each tourist to lean against the glacier and told them that after the condenser had been turned on for 15 minutes, they should slowly pour the water from their pails between their suits and the glacier. Some of the water would freeze, and the glacier would grow a bit. Not much, but with enough tourists, eventually there would be measurable progress.

He walked back to the water taxi to wait but midway, turned to watch the process from afar. The white suits of the tourists seemed to blend together, and Minik got a warm feeling imagining their bulk added to the recovery of the glacier. Sermitsiaq would still live! He snapped out of his reverie. No! His first responsibility was not to repair Nature but to take care of his human charges. What kind of guide is he if he can’t see the tourist for the Freeze?